UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

TOPIC 2: JOB APPLICATIONS AND INQUIRIES

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the importance of a well written job application for obtaining employment
- Explore several different ways to inquire about job openings

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Complete a sample job application and an e-mail inquiry to add to their Student Career portfolio
- Have the knowledge and skills to successfully complete various types of applications (paper and online)
- Create a professional e-mail account to use for employment-related communications

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will review sample employment application questions.
- Students will practice completing an employment application professionally and completely.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "A Job Seekers Guide to Successfully Completing a Job Application" and sample "Employment Application," pens/pencils

Read aloud (or have students take turns) from the "How to Fill Out a Job Application" handout. Emphasize that an application is more than a piece of paper; it is a chance to make a good impression with potential employers. Review each section of the sample "Employment Application" handout informing students about the required contents for each section and the importance of writing legibly.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objectives:
- Students will be aware of the basic information and expectations needed to successfully complete a job application.
- Students will have a completed sample job application for their portfolio and to reference in the future.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: sample "Employment Application" plus extras, pens/pencils

Ask students to fill out the sample "Employment Application" handout. The instructor should help students by answering questions, clarifying terms, and giving suggestions. Upon completion, ask students to proofread their work, and give it to the instructor to proofread as well. Ask students to place the completed sample job application in their Student Career Portfolio.

Technical/Research Activity 1

Objective: Students will be able to locate and complete job applications online.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection

Explain to students that many employers are now making applications available online. Ask students to complete the sample online job application at the following address: **http://www.careerkokua.org/js/jsa/article.cfm?id=12**.

After proofreading the online application, have students save the application to their electronic portfolio. If time allows, ask students to internet search for one or two regional businesses that accept online applications.

Technical/Research Activity 2

Objective: Students will have the skills and knowledge to inquire about a job opening by e-mail.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"How to make an E-mail Employment Inquiry,"** computers with internet connection

Inform students that in many cases, an e-mail inquiry into a job opening is appropriate. Hand out the sheet **"How to Make an E-mail Employment Inquiry,"** and read aloud the first page that explains when and how an e-mail inquiry is a good idea. Ask students to log on to either GMail or Yahoo, and ask them to follow the steps to create a "professional" e-mail account. A professional e-mail account should include their first and last names or initials. Inform students to avoid using nicknames or any other names/words that employers may view as "unprofessional." Reinforce that for employment correspondence it is important to have an e-mail address that is simple and serious. Having a separate e-mail account for "business" will help students stay organized, and keep personal and professional communication separate.

Using their new e-mail address, ask the students to make a sample e-mail inquiry to a local business which corresponds with their job interests, following the steps detailed on page 2 of the handout **"How to Make an E-mail Employment Inquiry."** When completed and proofread, ask students not to send them yet and to print a copy and place it in their Student Career Portfolio.

A Job-Seeker's Guide to Successfully Completing Job Applications

New to job-hunting? This article is designed to provide you with the critical information you need to successfully complete a job application. Should filling out an application be a stressful event? No. If you have a resume, you should have just about all the information you need. If you don't have a resume, now might be the time to create one.

When are job applications used by employers? For many part-time, entry-level, and blue collar jobs, employers use applications to screen potential employees; they use the information from the applications to determine who they are going to call for a job interview. For other types of jobs, applications are simply the paperwork the Human Resources department requires of all job applicants; employers often ask you to complete an application after they have invited you for an interview.

Why do employers use job applications? Many employers use applications as a way of standardizing the information they obtain from all job-seekers, including some things that you would not normally put on your resume. Your goal is to complete the application as completely and honestly as you can — all the time remembering that the application is a key marketing tool for you in the job-hunting process. Remember that some employers will use your application as a basis for deciding whether to call you for an interview.

So, armed with this knowledge, here are the ins and outs of completing job applications.

- **Arrive prepared with the information you need.** Be sure to bring your resume, social security card, driver's license, etc. You probably will also need addresses and phone numbers of previous employers, as well as starting and ending salaries for each previous job. It's always better if have too much information than not enough.

- **Read and follow instructions carefully.** Always take a few minutes to review the entire application. Some applications ask for information differently — and all have specific spaces in which you are expected to answer questions. Think of the application as your first test in following instructions.

- **Complete the application as neatly as possible.** Remember how important handwriting was in school? Neatness and legibility count; the application is a reflection of you. Consider typing it if you have access to a typewriter. If completing it by hand, be sure to use only a blue or black pen — and consider using an erasable pen or taking some "white-out" to fix minor mistakes. Don't fold, bend, or otherwise mar the application.

- **Tailor your answers to the job you are seeking.** Just as with your resume and cover letter, you want to focus your education and experience to the job at hand. Give details of skills and accomplishments, and avoid framing your experiences in terms of mere duties and responsibilities. Show why you are more qualified than other applicants for the position. Include experience from all sources, including previous jobs, school, clubs and organizations, and volunteer work. If you're having trouble identifying some of your skills, read our article about transferable skills.

- **Don't leave any blanks.** One of the reasons employers have you complete an application is because they want the same information from all job applicants. However, if there are questions that do not apply to you, simply respond with "not applicable," or "n/a." Do not write "see resume" when completing the application (but you can certainly attach your resume to the application).

- **Don't provide any negative information.** As with any job search correspondence, never offer negative information. Your goal with the application is to get an interview. Providing negative information (such as being fired from a job) just gives the employer a reason not to interview you.

- **Always answer questions truthfully.** The fastest way for an application to hit the trash can is to have a lie on it, but that doesn't mean you need to give complete answers either. For example, many applications ask your reason for leaving your last job. If you were fired or downsized, you should try to be as positive as possible and leave longer explanations for the interview; some experts recommend writing "job ended" as the reason you left your last job.

- **Do not put specific salary requirements.** It is way too early in the job-seeking process to allow yourself to be identified by a specific salary request. You don't want to give employers too much information too soon. In addition, employers often use this question as a screening device — and you don't want to be eliminated from consideration based on your answer. It's best to say "open" or "negotiable." You can find lots more information about all aspects of salary and benefits by going to our Salary Negotiation Tutorial.

- **Provide references.** Employers want to see that there are people who will provide objective information about you to them. Pick your references carefully — and make sure you ask if they are willing to be a reference for you before you list them. Where do you get references? From past employers, to teachers, to family friends. Most young job-seekers have a mix of professional and character references, while more experienced job-seekers focus on professional references who can speak of your skills and accomplishments.

- **Keep your application consistent with your resume.** Make sure all dates, names, titles, etc., on your application coincide with the information on your resume. Don't worry if the application is based on chronological employment while you have a functional resume. Don't know the difference between the two types of resumes? You might want to visit one of our Resume Tutorials.

- **Proofread your application before submitting it.** Once you've completed the application, sit back and take a moment to thoroughly proofread the document, checking for all errors — especially typos and misspellings.

One final word. Be prepared for all kinds of job applications, from simple one-page applications to multi-page applications; and some will be clean and crisp copies while others will appear to be photocopied a few too many times. Regardless, take your time and do the best you can, always keeping in the back of your mind the goal of the application — getting you an interview.

If you have not heard from the employer within a week of submitting your application, you should follow-up with the employer. There's truth to the "squeaky wheel" cliché. Ask for an interview — and ask to have your application kept on file.

by Randall S. Hansen, Ph.D.

Sample Employment Application Form

PLEASE PRINT ALL INFORMATION REQUESTED EXCEPT SIGNATURE

APPLICATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

APPLICANTS MAY BE TESTED FOR ILLEGAL DRUGS

PLEASE COMPLETE PAGES 1-4. DATE _____

Name _____
Last First Middle Maiden

Present address _____
Number Street City State Zip

How long _____ Social Security No. _____ – _____ – _____

Telephone (___)_____

If under 18, please list age _____

Position applied for (1) _____
and salary desired (2) _____
(Be specific)

Days/hours available to work
No Pref _____ Thur _____
Mon _____ Fri _____
Tue _____ Sat _____
Wed _____ Sun _____

How many hours can you work weekly? _____ Can you work nights? _____

Employment desired __ FULL-TIME ONLY __ PART-TIME ONLY __ FULL- OR PART-TIME

When available for work?_____

_____

TYPE OF SCHOOL	NAME OF SCHOOL	LOCATION (Complete mailing address)	NUMBER OF YEARS COMPLETED	MAJOR & DEGREE
High School				
College				
Bus. or Trade School				
Professional School				

HAVE YOU EVER BEEN CONVICTED OF A CRIME? __ No __ Yes

If yes, explain number of conviction(s), nature of offense(s) leading to conviction(s), how recently such offense(s) was/were committed, sentence(s) imposed, and type(s) of rehabilitation. _____

_____

PLEASE PRINT ALL INFORMATION REQUESTED EXCEPT SIGNATURE

APPLICATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

DO YOU HAVE A DRIVER'S LICENSE? __ Yes __ No

What is your means of transportation to work? _____

Driver's license number _____ State of issue _____ __ Operator __ Commercial (CDL) __ Chauffeur

Expiration date _____

Have you had any accidents during the past three years? How many? _____

Have you had any moving violations during the past three years? How Many? _____

OFFICE ONLY

Typing	__ Yes __ No	_____ WPM	10-key	__ Yes __ No	Word Processing	__ Yes __ No	_____ WPM
Personal Computer	__ Yes __ No	__ PC __ Mac	Other _____ Skills _____				

Please list two references other than relatives or previous employers.

Name _____	Name _____
Position _____	Position _____
Company _____	Company _____
Address _____	Address _____
_____	_____
Telephone (___) _____	Telephone (___) _____

An application form sometimes makes it difficult for an individual to adequately summarize a complete background. Use the space below to summarize any additional information necessary to describe your full qualifications for the specific position for which you are applying.

PLEASE PRINT ALL INFORMATION REQUESTED EXCEPT SIGNATURE

APPLICATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

MILITARY

HAVE YOU EVER BEEN IN THE ARMED FORCES? __ Yes __ No

ARE YOU NOW A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL GUARD? __ Yes __ No

Specialty _____ Date Entered _____ Discharge Date _____

Work Experience Please list your work experience for the **past five years** beginning with your most recent job held. If you were self-employed, give firm name. **Attach additional sheets if necessary.**

Name of employer Address City, State, Zip Code Phone number	Name of last supervisor	Employment dates	Pay or salary
		From To	Start Final
	Your last job title		
Reason for leaving (be specific)			
List the jobs you held, duties performed, skills used or learned, advancements or promotions while you worked at this company.			

Name of employer Address City, State, Zip Code Phone number	Name of last supervisor	Employment dates	Pay or salary
		From To	Start Final
	Your Last Job Title		
Reason for leaving (be specific)			
List the jobs you held, duties performed, skills used or learned, advancements or promotions while you worked at this company.			

PLEASE PRINT ALL INFORMATION REQUESTED EXCEPT SIGNATURE

APPLICATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

Work experience	Please list your work experience for the **past five years** beginning with your most recent job held. If you were self-employed, give firm name. **Attach additional sheets if necessary.**

Name of employer Address City, State, Zip Code Phone number	Name of last supervisor	Employment dates	Pay or salary
		From To	Start Final
	Your last job title		
Reason for leaving (be specific)			
List the jobs you held, duties performed, skills used or learned, advancements or promotions while you worked at this company.			

Name of employer Address City, State, Zip Code Phone number	Name of last supervisor	Employment dates	Pay or salary
		From To	Start Final
	Your last job title		
Reason for leaving (be specific)			
List the jobs you held, duties performed, skills used or learned, advancements or promotions while you worked at this company.			

May we contact your present employer? __ Yes __ No

Did you complete this application yourself __ Yes __ No

If not, who did? _____

How to Make An E-mail Employment Inquiry

YOUR FIRST CONTACT TO AN EMPLOYER:

- For a first contact, e-mail employers only when an employer specifically invites or instructs you to do so — with instructions on the employer's web site, a job ad, a verbal conversation, other reliable advice, etc.
- Don't send an e-mail randomly to someone saying "I'm not sure if you're the correct person, but I figured you could forward this..." Don't figure. If you write to the wrong person, s/he has no reason to respond or forward. Do your research, and say WHY you're writing to the person ("you were listed as the contact for the XYZ job fair").Otherwise, you may be safer sending a resume and cover letter via hard copy.

HOW TO SEND IT/E-MAIL BUSINESS ETIQUETTE:

- Your e-mail alias, your subject line, and your content all have to be clear and appear appropriate to your recipient. Failure to do this can get your e-mail ignored and/or deleted as junk or spam.
- "Hotdogdude@hotmail" or "Sillygirl75849@yahoo.com" are not appropriate. That is an excellent way <u>never</u> to be taken seriously or viewed as professional — or end up in a junk/spam filter.

YOUR SUBJECT LINE:

- Clear and meaningful to the recipient, as in: "Application for manufacturing position 84G11" or "Follow-up to our meeting of February 21 at Career Point job fair."
- A blank subject line is unacceptable. You've given the recipient a good reason to ignore or delete your e-mail.
- Be judicious about graphics and fonts. Large graphics (and moving graphics are worse) clog up memory in people's in-boxes. Don't do it. Same applies to backgrounds. Better safe than sorry. Fonts should be professional looking and easy to read.
- After your name, put all current contact information — phone numbers, address, and e-mail again.

FINAL CAUTIONS & CONSIDERATIONS:

- Be aware that e-mail is a form of written communication and it creates a written record.
- Don't let the speed and ease of sending e-mail blind you to the fact that you will be judged on what you say and how you say it.
- E-mail, like other written correspondence, doesn't reveal your tone of voice. Choose your words carefully.
- A well-written e-mail can quickly impress an employer (and the reverse is true).
- Don't forget to use the spell-check feature.

STEPS TO WRITING AN E-MAIL EMPLOYMENT INQUIRY:

- Try to get as specific as possible, if you don't have a specific person's e-mail, try the general department for which you would be applying, and write "To Whom It May Concern"
- Introduce yourself and mention where your information came from regarding the job *(My name is _____, and we spoke at XYZ Job Fair on June 11 regarding the _____opening at your business.)*
- Name a few skills, interests, and/or experiences you have had that would make you a good match for the job *(I have previously worked for ABC Catering, and I love to help prepare and serve food for special events).*
- Explain you would like to know more about the position, and what the next steps in applying would be.
- Always thank the person you are writing to for their time, and sign off Sincerely, _____.
- Don't forget to put your specific contact information below you name.
- Don't forget to spell check.

Adapted from Virginia Tech. Career Services — www.career.vt.edu